

Strategic Evolution and Sustainability Integration: A Comprehensive Analysis of Samsung C&T Corporation ESG Disclosures

The identification of the entity associated with the stock ticker 028260.KS is confirmed as Samsung C&T Corporation.¹ Samsung C&T Corporation is the de facto holding company of the Samsung Group, a position solidified following its complex and highly scrutinized merger with Cheil Industries in 2015.³ The corporation is a multi-industrial conglomerate headquartered in Seoul, South Korea, with a primary business focus divided into four distinct operational groups: Engineering & Construction (E&C), Trading & Investment (T&I), Fashion, and Resort.¹ Additionally, the company maintains significant equity interests in the group's biopharmaceutical subsidiaries, specifically Samsung Biologics and Samsung Bioepis, which are increasingly material to its consolidated ESG reporting profile.⁶ Within the global financial markets, Samsung C&T is classified under the Industrials sector and the Engineering & Construction industry, reflecting its significant role in global infrastructure development and industrial commodity trading.¹ Verification of these identifiers is supported by data from the Korea Exchange (KRX), Bloomberg, Reuters, and the company's official investor relations documentation.¹

Structural Evolution and the 2015 Merger Governance Legacy

The contemporary identity of Samsung C&T Corporation cannot be analyzed without a granular understanding of the 2015 merger, which serves as the foundational governance event for the entity.³ In September 2015, Cheil Industries, an entity primarily focused on fashion and resorts and controlled by the Lee family, absorbed the original Samsung C&T, a construction and trading giant.³ This transaction was executed at a merger ratio of 0.35 shares of Samsung C&T for every 1 share of Cheil Industries.³ This specific ratio became the center of a decade-long legal and ethical controversy, as critics and international activist investors, most notably Elliott Management, argued that the ratio was engineered to undervalue the original Samsung C&T to facilitate the intergenerational transfer of control to Jay Y. Lee, the heir apparent to the Samsung empire.³

The governance implications of this merger were profound, creating what many analysts identified as a significant "Korea Discount" on the company's valuation.¹⁵ The legal proceedings following the merger encompassed charges of stock price manipulation, accounting fraud at

Samsung Biologics, and breach of trust.³ It was alleged that the Future Strategy Office (FSO), a powerful internal control tower within the Samsung Group, orchestrated the timing and valuation of the merger to ensure a favorable outcome for the Lee family at the expense of minority shareholders and the National Pension Service (NPS), which held a critical voting stake.³ The subsequent litigation lasted until July 2025, when the Supreme Court of South Korea finally acquitted Jay Y. Lee of all financial criminal charges related to the merger, ruling that there was insufficient evidence of an illegal scheme to manipulate the market.³ However, the reputational damage from this period forced Samsung C&T to pioneer radical governance reforms that would eventually lead to its high ESG ratings in the 2020s.¹⁷

ESG Report Timeline and Disclosure Evolution (2014–2023)

The decade between 2014 and 2023 represents the transformation of Samsung C&T's reporting from promotional Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) brochures to rigorous, data-driven ESG disclosures aligned with international financial standards.⁵ This evolution was driven by the necessity to regain investor trust and align with the South Korean government's increasing focus on corporate transparency.¹⁷

The CSR and Integration Phase (2014–2016)

In 2014, the reporting focused on "Green Management" and social contribution, with the entity then known as Cheil Industries (following the renaming of Samsung Everland) being listed on the Dow Jones Sustainability Index (DJSI) World for the first time.⁷ These early reports followed the GRI G4 guidelines and focused on qualitative narratives regarding community engagement and environmental footprint reduction in the resort and fashion sectors.⁵ Following the 2015 merger, the 2016 report marked the first integrated disclosure of the combined E&C, T&I, Fashion, and Resort groups, setting a baseline for the company's new industrial profile.⁵

Institutionalizing ESG Oversight (2017–2019)

As global standards for climate-related financial disclosures matured, Samsung C&T began to align its internal structures with external expectations.¹⁸ In 2018, the company published its third post-merger report, which was recognized by the Korea Institute of Corporate Governance and Sustainability (KCGS) with a "Best Company" award, signaling a recovery in domestic governance perceptions.⁵ By October 2019, the Board of Directors took a decisive step by approving a plan to upgrade the entire ESG operation system, moving sustainability from a peripheral support function to a central strategic pillar.¹⁸ This internal reorganization was crucial for the subsequent adoption of more rigorous reporting frameworks.¹⁷

The Climate Leadership and Framework Maturity Phase (2020–2023)

The period beginning in 2020 saw the most rapid advancement in Samsung C&T's ESG maturity.⁷ In October 2020, the company made a landmark "Coal-Exit" declaration, committing to cease all new involvement in coal-fired power projects, a response to significant pressure from global institutional investors and the risk of "brand contagion" affecting Samsung Electronics.⁷ In March 2021, the company formalized its commitment by expanding the Governance Committee into a full ESG Committee under the Board of Directors, ensuring that independent directors had direct oversight of environmental and social risks.¹⁷ This period also saw the full-scale adoption of the Task Force on Climate-related Financial Disclosures (TCFD) and the Sustainability Accounting Standards Board (SASB) standards, providing the market with standardized metrics on carbon intensity and safety performance.²³ By 2022, the company announced its comprehensive 2050 Net Zero roadmap, followed by an upgrade to an integrated "A+" rating from KCGS in 2023.⁷

Year	Key ESG Milestone or Disclosure Development	Framework/Agency Relevance	Source Citation
2014	First-time inclusion in DJSI World Index	DJSI / Benchmark	⁷
2015	Merger of Cheil Industries and Samsung C&T	Governance / Structural	³
2018	Third post-merger report; KCGS "Best Company"	KCGS / GRI	⁵
2020	Official "Coal-Exit" (탈석탄) Declaration	Environmental / Risk	⁷
2021	Establishment of Board-level ESG Committee	Governance / Reform	¹⁷
2021	First detailed TCFD and SASB alignment	TCFD / SASB	⁷

2022	Announcement of 2050 Net Zero Roadmap	Environmental / Strategy	⁷
2023	Awarded Integrated "A+" Rating by KCGS	KCGS / Validation	⁷
2023	7th consecutive year in DJSI World Index	DJSI / Benchmark	⁷

Engineering & Construction: Sustainable Infrastructure and Net Zero Implementation

The Engineering & Construction (E&C) Group is the most carbon-intensive and safety-critical division of Samsung C&T, and its ESG performance is central to the group's overall rating.¹ Historically known for world-class civil engineering projects, the division has shifted its focus from fossil fuel infrastructure to green buildings, renewable energy plants, and hydrogen economy infrastructure.⁷

The Vung Ang 2 Controversy and Reputational Contagion

The construction of the Vung Ang 2 coal-fired power plant in Vietnam serves as the primary material controversy for the E&C group during the 2014-2023 period.²¹ Environmental groups, including Market Forces and SFOC, highlighted significant flaws in the project's Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA), such as the use of inappropriate air pollution dispersion models and the discharge of thermal effluent exceeding international limits.²⁸ This project drew the ire of global investors like BlackRock and LGIM, who warned that Samsung's continued involvement in coal contradicted its public sustainability pledges.²² The controversy was so severe that it triggered a public admission from Samsung Electronics executives that the construction unit's coal projects were damaging the brand value of Galaxy smartphones.²¹ This realization was the primary driver behind the 2020 Coal-Exit declaration, a strategic pivot intended to decouple the Samsung brand from the fossil fuel industry.⁷

Pivot to Renewable Energy and Green Hydrogen

Following the Coal-Exit, the E&C Group aggressively repositioned itself as a leader in sustainable construction.⁷ The division has successfully executed large-scale renewable projects, such as the Ontario wind and solar cluster, and has expanded into Energy Storage Systems (ESS).⁷ In 2023, the group signed a contract for a 3GW solar power and ESS project in

Texas, marking one of its largest entries into the U.S. renewable market.⁷ Furthermore, the company is a lead participant in the Oman Green Ammonia project, aiming for a production capacity of 1 million tons per year by 2030, which exemplifies its strategy to transition from a construction contractor to a comprehensive green energy developer.⁷

Safety Management and Technological Innovation

Safety remains the highest social ("S") priority for the E&C Group. To mitigate the risks inherent in high-rise and infrastructure projects, the company has integrated Building Information Modeling (BIM) and automation technologies.⁷ In 2021, Samsung C&T became the first domestic construction company to obtain international standard certification for BIM, which enhances project predictability and worker safety.⁷ The company also utilizes an internal safety monitoring system that leverages AI and IoT to detect hazardous conditions at job sites in real-time, a development that contributed to its "A+" social rating from KCGS in 2023.⁷

Trading & Investment: From Commodities to Green Energy Organizing

The Trading & Investment (T&I) Group has traditionally focused on the global trade of chemicals, steel, and energy resources.¹ In the context of the corporation's ESG transition, this division has evolved from a traditional commodity trader into a "green energy project organizer".¹⁸ This shift is significant because it moves the company up the value chain, focusing on project development and the supply of transition minerals rather than the simple arbitrage of fossil fuels.¹

Supply Chain Management and Ethical Sourcing

The T&I group plays a critical role in managing the environmental and social risks of Samsung C&T's vast supply chain.³² Under the GRI and SASB reporting frameworks, the division must disclose its due diligence processes for minerals and chemicals.⁹ This includes regular audits of suppliers to ensure compliance with the Supplier Code of Conduct, particularly regarding labor rights and the prohibition of child labor in mineral sourcing.²³ The company has expanded its supply chain sector efforts by conducting third-party audits on second-tier suppliers, reflecting an increasing depth of oversight as global regulations like the EU's Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD) loom.³⁵

Resource Circularity and Sustainable Materials

Aligned with the corporation's Net Zero goals, the T&I group has increased its focus on recycled materials, particularly in the steel and polymer sectors.¹ By 2023, the division began prioritizing the trade of "green steel" (produced with lower carbon intensity) and recycled resins, directly supporting the Resource Circularity Roadmap of its affiliate, Samsung Electronics.³² This

integration demonstrates the third-order insight that Samsung C&T uses its trading arm to secure the sustainable inputs required by the broader group, thereby reducing consolidated Scope 3 emissions.²³

Fashion and Resort: Social Impact and Consumer-Facing ESG

While smaller in revenue compared to the E&C and T&I groups, the Fashion and Resort divisions are the most visible to the public and carry significant weight in the corporation's social and environmental reputation.¹ These divisions have historically pioneered "Green Management" within the company, dating back to 2014.⁷

Fashion Group: Circularity and Sustainable Logistics

The Fashion Group has established a circular economy roadmap that includes the use of recycled fibers and the reduction of packaging waste.³² In 2022, the division became the first Korean fashion company to renew its ISMS-P certification, reflecting a commitment to data privacy and information security in its e-commerce operations.⁷ Furthermore, the division has integrated ESG criteria into its supplier evaluations, providing training to small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) to improve their environmental and labor practices.³³

Resort Group: Biodiversity and Customer Experience

The Resort Group, which operates Everland and Caribbean Bay, focuses on biodiversity protection and landscaping as key environmental pillars.¹ The division has won international awards for its rose variety developments and maintains significant landscaping projects that contribute to urban carbon sequestration.⁷ Socially, the group consistently ranks first in the Korean Customer Satisfaction Index (KCSI) and the Korean Standard-Service Quality Index (KS-SQI), reflecting high performance in service quality and customer safety.⁷ The division's management of the giant panda "Bao family" has also been used as a tool for public engagement and environmental awareness, highlighting the softer side of the corporation's ESG strategy.⁷

Governance Reform and the Independent Board Structure

The governance ("G") pillar has undergone the most radical transformation of the three ESG categories at Samsung C&T.¹⁷ Following the acquittal of Jay Y. Lee and the dissolution of the Future Strategy Office, the company has worked to institutionalize a "board-centric" management model to prevent the recurrence of the 2015 merger controversies.³

The ESG Committee and Independent Oversight

The establishment of the ESG Committee in March 2021 was a watershed moment.¹⁷ Composed entirely of independent directors, the committee is responsible for deliberating on major sustainability policies, including the Net Zero roadmap and shareholder return plans.¹⁷ This committee also merged with the Related Party Transaction Committee in 2022, strengthening its ability to monitor and regulate transactions with other Samsung affiliates, a historical area of weakness in chaebol governance.¹⁷

Shareholder Rights and Communication

To address the concerns of institutional and minority shareholders, Samsung C&T has implemented several communication mechanisms.¹⁷ The company now appoints a "Shareholder Advocate" within the ESG Committee to ensure that the voices of external stakeholders reach the board.¹⁷ Additionally, the company has committed to a transparent dividend payout plan and a three-year shareholder return policy for the FY2023-2025 period, aimed at increasing the total return to shareholders through buybacks and cancellations of treasury shares.¹⁷

Governance Metric	Current Status (2023/24)	Institutional Significance	Source
Board Chair	Independent Director (since 2021)	Separation of ownership and management	¹⁷
ESG Committee	100% Independent Directors	Objective oversight of E&S risks	¹⁷
Auditor Independence	Audit Team under Audit Committee	Integrity of financial/non-financial data	¹⁷
Shareholder Rights	Shareholder Advocate appointed	Improved communication with minority investors	¹⁷
Voting System	Electronic voting	Increased participation in	¹⁷

	implemented	AGM	
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ESG Ratings Trajectory and Benchmarking Analysis (2014-2023)

The success of Samsung C&T’s ESG transformation is validated by its performance in major domestic and global ratings.⁷ The trajectory shows a clear recovery from the post-merger governance crisis to a position of global leadership in the construction and engineering sector.⁷

MSCI ESG Ratings: The Path to AAA

MSCI ESG Ratings categorize companies from AAA (leader) to CCC (laggard) based on their management of material ESG risks.³⁴ Samsung C&T remained at the "A" level for several years as it worked through its governance reforms.⁷ In 2023, the company was upgraded to "AA" as MSCI noted significant improvements in corporate governance practices and responsible mineral sourcing policies.³⁴ By late 2024, historical data indicates the company reached the "AAA" status, the highest possible grade, reflecting a best-in-class risk management profile.⁷

KCGS Ratings: Domestic Validation

The Korea Institute of Corporate Governance and Sustainability (KCGS) is the primary domestic evaluator of ESG performance in South Korea.⁷ Samsung C&T has maintained an "A" rating for seven consecutive years, reflecting steady progress.⁷ In 2023, the entity achieved an integrated "A+" grade, with individual scores of "A" for Environmental and "A+" for both Social and Governance.⁷ This "A+" rating is particularly prestigious in the Korean market, where governance scores for large conglomerates are historically depressed.⁷

CDP and DJSI: Sustained Excellence

The company’s performance in the Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP) has been exemplary, with Samsung C&T being included in the "Platinum Club" of the CDP Korea Awards for three consecutive years (2020-2022) and reaching the "Hall of Fame".⁷ In the Dow Jones Sustainability Indices (DJSI), the company has been included in the World Index for seven consecutive years as of 2023, maintaining its position in the top 10% of global companies in the construction and engineering sector.⁷

Rating Agency	2018 Status	2020 Status	2023/24 Status	Improvement Driver	Source
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MSCI	N/A (unverified)	A	AA / AAA	Governance reform & Mineral sourcing	7
KCGS	Best Company	A (Integrated)	A+ (Integrated)	ESG Committee & Safety tech	7
DJSI	World Index	World Index	World Index (7th yr)	Sustained operational efficiency	7
CDP	Hall of Fame	Platinum Club	Hall of Fame (Level A)	Coal-Exit & Net Zero roadmap	7

Analysis of Reporting Frameworks and Assurance Integrity

Samsung C&T's ESG reporting is structured to meet the divergent needs of various stakeholders, utilizing a "multi-framework" approach that ensures both breadth and depth.⁹

Framework Application and Relevance

The company utilizes the GRI Standards for general impact reporting, providing a narrative on its contribution to the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).⁹ For institutional investors, the TCFD framework provides critical data on the financial implications of climate change, while SASB standards provide industry-specific metrics such as the percentage of buildings certified to green standards (e.g., LEED) and Total Recordable Incident Rate (TRIR) for its workers.²⁴ This integrated approach allows the company to minimize the information gap between management and external shareholders.¹⁷

Third-Party Assurance and Data Verifiability

To ensure the integrity of its non-financial data, Samsung C&T employs rigorous third-party assurance.¹⁹ Historically, the company's reports have been verified by the Korea Management Registrar (KMR) and the British Standards Institution (BSI).³⁷ These audits verify the company's reporting processes against the AA1000AS v3 standard, assessing the inclusivity, materiality, responsiveness, and impact of the reported information.⁴³ For greenhouse gas (GHG)

emissions, the company commissions separate verification reports in accordance with ISO 14064, providing a high level of confidence in its progress toward Net Zero.⁴³

Reference Table and Source Credibility Assessment

The analysis presented in this report is derived from a wide range of primary and secondary sources, each evaluated for its authority and potential for bias.

#	Reference (APA 7th edition format)	Source Type	Credibility Score (0–10)	Justification for Score	Relevance to Query
1	Samsung C&T Corporation. (2024). <i>Samsung C&T Letter to Shareholders and 2023 Earnings</i> .	Primary	10	Official corporate disclosure filed with regulators; audited financial/ESG data.	High: Primary identification and performance.
2	Korea Exchange (KRX). (2026). <i>Stock Quote and Company Information: 028260.KS</i> .	Primary	10	Official stock exchange data; highest level of identification authority.	High: Identification and sector.
3	Samsung C&T Corporation. (2023). <i>History of Samsung C&T: ESG</i>	Primary	9	Official corporate record, though potentially self-promotio	High: Timeline of ESG reporting.

	Milestones.			nal in tone.	
4	MSCI ESG Research LLC. (2024). <i>ESG Ratings Summary: Samsung C&T.</i>	Secondary	9	Leading global ESG rating agency; standardized and independent methodology.	High: Performance benchmarking.
5	Korea Institute of Corporate Governance and Sustainability (KCGS). (2023). <i>ESG Ratings Search: Samsung C&T.</i>	Secondary	9	Semi-official domestic evaluator with high authority in the Korean market.	High: Domestic ESG scores.
6	Reuters/Yonhap. (2025). <i>South Korea Supreme Court Acquits Jay Y. Lee in Merger Case.</i>	Secondary	8	Reputable news outlets reporting on definitive legal proceedings.	High: Governance controversy context.

7	Market Forces. (2020). <i>Vung Ang 2 Coal Power Plant Environmental Risk Analysis</i> .	NGO Report	6	Specialized technical data but carries an advocacy bias against fossil fuels.	Medium: Context for coal controversy.
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Transparency and Knowledge Limitations

This report is based on research current as of March 19, 2026. While every effort has been made to verify the data points provided, certain limitations inherent in ESG reporting must be acknowledged.

Limitations in Data Access

1. **Paywalled Granularity:** While final ESG ratings (e.g., "AA" or "A+") are publicly disclosed, the underlying sub-scores for specific pillars (e.g., carbon emissions per dollar of revenue) are often contained in proprietary databases like Bloomberg Terminal or Refinitiv, which were not directly accessed for raw data points.²
2. **Historical Reporting Variations:** The quality of reporting in the 2014-2016 period is qualitatively lower and less standardized than contemporary reports, as the industry was then transitioning from GRI G4 to more modular standards.⁵
3. **Subsidiary Consolidation:** Samsung C&T's reports increasingly integrate data from Samsung Biologics and Samsung Bioepis. However, the exact boundaries of non-financial data consolidation (e.g., whether Scope 3 includes all biopharma supply chains) are sometimes unclear in the executive summaries.⁸

Unverified Claims and Speculation

Any statements regarding Jay Y. Lee's specific intentions during the 2015 merger remain "unverified" from a legal perspective, as the Supreme Court has cleared him of criminal intent, despite persistent skepticism from academic and activist observers.³ This report treats the acquittal as a verified legal fact but acknowledges the merger as a "material controversy" based on its impact on the company's governance ratings during the period.³

Recommended Verification Sources

For independent verification of the claims made in this report, users are encouraged to consult:

- **Samsung C&T Investor Relations (ESG Resource Center):** For direct downloads of

annual sustainability and corporate governance reports.⁴⁸

- **CDP Search Tool:** For detailed climate change and water security responses.²³
- **DART (Data Analysis, Retrieval and Transfer System):** The South Korean FSS portal for official regulatory and financial filings.¹⁷

Conclusion: Synthesis of ESG Leadership and Future Resilience

The analysis of Samsung C&T Corporation's ESG journey from 2014 to 2023 reveals a company that has successfully utilized a series of high-profile crises to reinvent its operational philosophy. The governance trauma of the 2015 merger and the environmental backlash from the Vung Ang 2 coal project were not merely reputational setbacks; they served as the primary mechanisms for structural change. The transition to a board-centric management model, the appointment of an independent chair, and the decisive "Coal-Exit" have decoupled the corporation from its historical "chaebol" risks.

The third-order insight from this study is that Samsung C&T's ESG strategy is now a defensive moat against the "Korea Discount." By aligning with international disclosure frameworks like TCFD and SASB and achieving elite ratings from MSCI and KCGS, the company has signaled to global capital markets that it is no longer a mere family-controlled vehicle but a professionally managed, sustainability-focused industrial giant. Looking forward, the company's ability to maintain its "AAA" and "A+" ratings will depend on the successful execution of its 2050 Net Zero roadmap and its continued leadership in the green hydrogen and renewable energy sectors. For institutional investors and professional peers, Samsung C&T serves as a global benchmark for how a diversified industrial conglomerate can navigate the complex intersection of corporate succession, climate change, and shareholder activism.

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